35. Chakras — origins, the seven centres, nadis, Kundalini and how to meditate with them

Oracle OS guide. Based on the Hatha Yoga Pradipika and the Yoga Sutras (in the library), the *Ṣaṭ-cakra-nirūpaṇa* (Pūrṇānanda, 1577) translated by Sir John Woodroffe ("Arthur Avalon") in *The Serpent Power* (1919), and historical scholarship on tantra.

What they are — and what they are not

- *Cakra* is Sanskrit for "wheel" or "circle". In Hindu and Buddhist tantric texts (8th–16th centuries) they are **centres of concentration** visualised along the body's axis, used as a map for meditation, mantra and visualisation.
- **The number varies** by tradition: tantric Buddhism usually has 4 or 5; several Hindu texts give 6 + 1 (the best known today, from the *Ṣaṭ-cakra-nirūpaṇa*); others give more.
- The **rainbow colours** (red → violet) linked to 7 chakras are a 20th-century Western creation; the old texts describe different colours for each lotus.
- There is no scientific evidence that chakras are physical structures or that they cure disease. As an **attention and relaxation practice** they are safe and can calm. They don't replace medical treatment.

The channels (nadis) and Kundalini

- **Sushumna**: central channel along the spine.
- **Ida** (left, lunar, calming) and **Pingala** (right, solar, activating) twist around Sushumna. Alternate-nostril breathing (Nadi Shodhana) aims to balance them.
- **Kundalini**: energy described as a sleeping serpent coiled at the base of the spine; in tantric practice it awakens and rises through Sushumna, piercing the chakras up to the crown.

The seven chakras (the most widespread Hindu system)

Chakra	Location	Element	Bija (seed sound)	Petals	Colour in old texts	Modern colour	Traditional/ modern themes
Muladhara (root)	base of spine / perineum	earth	LAM	4	yellow square, crimson petals	red	stability, survival, safety
Svadhisthana (sacral)	lower belly / genitals	water	VAM	6	white crescent, vermilion petals	orange	creativity, emotion, sexuality
Manipura (navel / solar plexus)	navel	fire	RAM	10	red triangle, dark blue petals	yellow	will, energy, digestion
Anahata (heart)	centre of chest	air	YAM	12	smoky hexagram, bright red petals	green	love, compassion, connection

Chakra	Location	Element	Bija (seed sound)	Petals	Colour in old texts	Modern colour	Traditional/ modern themes
Vishuddha (throat)	throat	ether / space	HAM	16	white circle, smoky purple petals	blue	expression, truth, com munication
Ajna (third eye)	between the brows	mind	OM	2	white	indigo	intuition, dis cernment
Sahasrara (crown)	top of the head	beyond the elements	(silence / OM)	1000	brilliant white	violet / white	unity, awareness

Similar systems elsewhere

- **Tibetan Buddhism**: channels (tsa), winds (lung) and drops (tigle); chakras at the crown, throat, heart and navel (sometimes the secret place), with the syllables OM, AH, HUM.
- **Taoism**: three **dantian** — lower (below the navel, vital energy), middle (heart, emotions) and upper (between the brows, spirit); the microcosmic orbit.
- **Sufism**: *lataif* (subtleties) at points in the chest and head, worked with dhikr.

How to meditate with the chakras (20–30 minutes)

1. Sit upright, eyes closed, 10 slow belly breaths.
2. Bring attention to the **base of the spine**. Feel contact with the ground. If you like, chant "LAM" 3–7 times (or silently) feeling the vibration there. Imagine a light (red, or any colour you prefer) and the quality of **safety and stability**.
3. Move up to the **lower belly** — "VAM", flow. Then the **navel** — "RAM", calm strength. The **heart** — "YAM", tenderness and compassion (you can add loving-kindness). The **throat** — "HAM", true speech. **Between the brows** — "OM", clarity. The **crown** — silence, openness.
4. 1–3 minutes at each centre. At the end, imagine light running up the spine and back down, and rest in silence.
5. **Close by coming down**: bring attention back to the feet and the ground, move the hands, open the eyes. This prevents feeling "light-headed".

Short versions

- **Spinal breath**: breathing in, feel attention rise from base to crown; breathing out, descend. 5 minutes.
- **Heart only**: hand on the chest, breathe into the centre of the chest, repeat "YAM" or a loving-kindness phrase.
- **Rooting** in moments of fear: feet on the ground, weight in the legs, slow breath, attention at the base of the body.

Cautions

- Intense Kundalini practices (long breath retention, strong bandhas, hours of concentration) can cause dizziness, insomnia, anxiety, heat or uncontrolled energy sensations ("Kundalini crisis"). Do them only with an experienced teacher.

- Avoid breath retention with high blood pressure, heart disease, pregnancy, epilepsy or a history of psychosis.
- If physical symptoms appear (chest pain, breathlessness, numbness), treat them as medical, not as "energy".